Dad's Care Plan and Dad's Week Don't Quite Match: The First Three Things to Do

Three first moves, in order, and what to leave for later.

The schedule on the fridge says one thing. What your sister tells you about Dad's week says another. You can't tell yet whether something is being missed or whether it just hasn't been checked.

You don't have to settle that today. There are three first moves, and they go in order.

1 Put the plan and the week on one sheet

List what Dad needs help with, from the care plan and from what you've seen yourself. Beside each need, write who is supposed to cover it: the agency, your sister, someone else, or nobody yet. Then mark each line “seen” if you or someone you can name watched it happen this week, and “scheduled” if you're going on the paperwork. Include what your sister does that isn't on any schedule. [1]

WHY THIS ORDER Until the paper and the week sit side by side, you're comparing a document with a feeling.

2 Ask about the lines you're not sure of

For every line marked “scheduled,” and every blank, write who could tell you: Dad, your sister, the agency's office, his nurse. Ask Dad first. Then ask the others plainly, without sounding critical: “Can you tell me which days someone came last week?” Write the answer and the date beside the line. If the help comes from a Medicare-certified home health agency, Medicare's booklet says to take a question about the care to both his provider and the home health team. [2] [3]

WHY THIS ORDER Asking comes before concluding. A line you haven't confirmed isn't a failure. It's a question nobody has put to the person who knows.

3 Put one name beside everything still open

Whatever is still unanswered after you've asked, and any need with nobody beside it, gets one name: the person who will make the next call or find out. Write down what each person has agreed to do, so nobody has to carry it in their head. [4]

WHY THIS ORDER Once you can see what's open, a name beside each line keeps it from being everyone's job and no one's.

What can wait

- Whether anything about Dad's care should change.
- Whether the agency, the aide or anyone in the family is doing enough. You don't know yet, and this week you don't need to.
- How the family shares the work in the long run.
- What the open lines mean for Dad. That takes the people who assess him, and your one sheet is what makes that conversation specific.

> **One thing that isn't for the sheet**
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> A worry about Dad's health itself. If something you see leaves you concerned about how he is doing, that isn't a line for the sheet. The National Institute on Aging's advice is to suggest a visit to a health care provider, so call his doctor's office and say what you saw. In an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether Dad's care is working, whether any service has fallen short, or what should change. It gives you a place to start and an order to work in.

Ready for the next step?

You've put the plan and the week on one sheet, asked about the lines you weren't sure of, and put a name beside what's still open. The care interview widens the view: it goes through Dad's daily life area by area and records who covers each part, so the comparison rests on a whole picture, and it turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Working out what care is needed and who is responsible for which tasks follows the National Institute on Aging, as do the advice to ask the person directly and to raise a worry without sounding critical. Taking questions to the provider and the home health team follows Medicare's home health booklet, which is written about Medicare-certified agencies. Writing down what each person has agreed to follows the Family Caregiver Alliance. The order, and the habit of marking a line “seen” or “scheduled,” are ours.

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Medicare & Home Health Care (CMS Product No. 10969)
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting

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